above, part of the answer can also be found in the use or even the threat to use gender-based violence. Violence undermines women's ability to participate effectively in peace- and state-building activities as do other forms of gender-based violence that go unaddressed. In concert with actual threats to security, male invocation of a gender discourse where women are "in need of protection" ensures the continuation of men's privilege and power over women and access to resources. An example of how this narrative is used to prohibit women from participating in political activities is aptly captured in the following quote from a Kachin woman who sought to participate in peace negotiations as part of a government team:

> I requested Minister U Aung Min to include me as a member of the negotiation team for the talks with KIO. But he told me that the road to the place where the talk would be held is so bad and it is not easy for women to travel. Actually, the place where the talk would be held is not an unfamiliar place for me. It is really nonsense that a responsible woman for her own people was not allowed to go there. The reason was so meaningless.[13]

Gendered insecurity (real or imagined) is important for understanding women's exclusion from political decision-making and helps to contextualise women's response to the conflict as community-wide experiences of gender-based violence propels women to support the KIO/KIA. In other words, forms of gender-based violence, such as trafficking or rape, perpetrated by people outside the Kachin community have been discursively positioned as evidence of discrimination and threat to the Kachin people, and thus as a key factor for conflict. Consequently, violence against women in Myanmar is being filtered and made sense of through ethnic and religious lenses, which has resulted in making largely invisible violence perpetrated against women *within* Kachin communities (see Roy 2012, p. 129). As one community activist says: "I have never heard of [violence] happening within Kachin liberated areas. But in Burmese areas I hear that it is likely to happen."[14]

There is then a hierarchy of violence, in which gender, religion, and ethnicity play key roles. A recent study on civilian women and men's views in the peace process noted a significant statistical relationship between self-identified Kachin Christian women and feelings of physical insecurity compared to men and women of other ethnic and religious identities living in Kachin State (MPC 2015, pp. 100–1). Insecurity is gendered, and women are responding to the insecurity they experience by, for example, supporting the KIO/KIA.